age of fifteen there was a whisper that Nottinghamshire, a county with strong links to the Bedford coaches, were after me.

I don't consider myself insecure for recognizing my fear of failure. Doubt has always been there, but manageable. Motivation for the extra batting sessions, or the early morning runs, varies; for some it is the prospect of adulation, basking in the crowd's warmth as they walk off, bat up, helmet removed to reveal a reddened face and sweat-streaked hair.

There's nothing wrong with that sort of egotism. It's earned and legitimate. Sometimes the exuberance of the celebration is a sign of relief, an acknowledgement of the inner struggle. Everyone loves a pat on the back, but I was simply driven to do it all again the next day. Success counts for nothing if it is not repeatable.

I knew the big score would be irrelevant if I failed the next four times I was at the crease. That's what kept me back, as the last man hitting balls. That's what made me train harder than anyone in my generation. I had to have an edge in personal fitness, because the regimes now employed by the likes of Ben Stokes, Jos Buttler and Jonny Bairstow – proper athletes – were giving the game a different dimension.

My breakthrough moment as a young pro was discovering the meaning of mental toughness. It involved dealing with the Gimp, the bloke on my shoulder who loved to beat me up in moments of difficulty. The day I learned to live with him, and not become too down on myself, was a massive turning point in terms of my career's longevity.

This is not the it-was-better-in-my-day rumination of an old pro, but I watch some young county cricketers train today and wonder whether they appreciate the privilege of the life-changing opportunity they have been given. Why wouldn't you do more than the standard session, between nine and lunchtime? Why wouldn't you do that little bit more than the next man?

God-given talent offers no insurance. Will you fulfil your potential if you've half an eye on that afternoon on the golf course, or the session on the sofa, playing *FIFA* with your mates? Cricket has rewarded me with everything I have. There are no short cuts. I was lucky that I knew the value of hard work from an early age. I love it when I see younger players taking the same approach.

Maybe their programmes are too precise, too considered. My generation worked more on instinct and had greater self-awareness. I'm imperfect: I'm not the quickest and probably didn't do enough preparatory work with the